

~~SECRET~~

Endgame Strategy: A Sustainable Defense of a Viable Bosnia after UNPROFOR Withdrawal

Summary: If UNPROFOR withdraws, there is a serious risk that, left on its own, the Bosnian government will be unable to defend the territory it currently holds. A limited package of US assistance, sufficient to ensure the Bosnian government's survival as a viable entity, would serve important US interests. This support would consist of a military assistance package limited in quantity and types of weapons to material needed for defending existing Bosnian held territory, training outside Bosnia, and limited air strikes in the event of Serb air or heavy weapon attacks on Bosnian territory that threaten the Bosnians' ability to ensure their own defense. It would also include an economic package of assistance to help the Bosnian government rebuild and ensure the viability of the Bosnian state.

To improve Bosnia's long-term prospects, and to reduce the requirements for US assistance, we would continue to foster closer links between Bosnia and Croatia through the Federation and Confederation. Because this approach is likely to be acceptable to at least some US allies (as well as some Islamic nations that support Bosnia) US assistance is likely to be supplemented by others.

Rationale: In the immediate aftermath of UNPROFOR's withdrawal, the Bosnian government is likely to find itself at a serious military disadvantage. The long-term impact of the arms embargo and the Serbs' advantage in heavy weaponry and aircraft create a risk that the Bosnian Serbs could make quick military gains, jeopardizing the government's survival. Simply lifting the embargo, without more active US assistance, is unlikely to remedy this situation for several reasons: 1) weapons may not arrive in time to halt devastating Serb offensives; 2) a period of training will be required for some of the needed weaponry; and 3) lifting the embargo could bring Belgrade more actively into the war on the Bosnian Serb side before the weapons reach Sarajevo, further jeopardizing the survival of the Bosnian government in the short-run. Failure of the United States to provide at least limited assistance would require the Bosnian government to depend almost exclusively on Islamic states, especially radical states such as Iran and Libya, increasing their influence in the region and polarizing the conflict. Lack of US involvement would also limit our ability to influence the parties in favor of a political settlement.

Actions required: At the time of the decision to withdraw UNPROFOR, the US would announce its intention to provide

~~SECRET~~

Decl: OADR

CLINTON LIBRARY PHOTOCOPY

DECLASSIFIED
PER E.O. 13526

limited assistance to the Bosnian government to ensure their defense, and seek agreement among the P-5 to lift the embargo following completion of UNPROFOR's withdrawal (this may require concessions to Russia on lifting the embargo and sanctions against Serbia). If agreement cannot be reached to repeal the embargo, the US would provide assistance directly using an Article 51 rationale (either overtly or covertly). An arms package focused on remedying defensive deficiencies (e.g. anti-tank and counter-artillery, air defense, perhaps C2 and intelligence) would be developed in conjunction with the Bosnia government; we would help assemble the package with contributions from as broad as possible group of contributors. Any training required by US personnel would take place outside Bosnia; arrangements would be made for transportation of weapons to Bosnia through Croatia. We would also seek NATO agreement for limited airstrikes pursuant to Article 51 of the Charter in the event that Serb offensives threatened to overrun Bosnian defenses (this could also be done pursuant to a UNSC Chapter VII resolution, but the dual key issues make this undesirable.)

Assuring the survival of the Bosnian government serves important US interests: Allowing the Serbs to defeat the Bosnian government is contrary a number of important US interests, including our commitment to resist aggression against sovereign states, the humanitarian and human rights consequences of a total Serb victory, the erosion of US credibility, the impact on US relations with the Islamic world, and the consequences for the region (e.g. the Krajina, Kosovo, Macedonia) of the consolidation of greater Serbia.

Need to limit scope of US assistance: Nonetheless, an open-ended commitment has substantial costs. Limiting the scope of US assistance will help serve important additional US interests that would be jeopardized if our aid extended to helping the Bosnian government recover (through combat) all or part of the territory now held by Serbs.

- Limiting our assistance to defensive operations is more likely to gain the support of our allies (who would face important domestic and international costs if Bosnia were overrun entirely), permitting a multilateral approach to lifting the arms embargo and military assistance. Multilateral lift would protect our interest in maintaining the integrity of UN Security Council Resolutions, avoid Americanizing the conflict, and avoid serious inter-Alliance rifts that could further jeopardize NATO. US support for Bosnian offensive operations would be opposed by our allies.

- Similarly, a limited approach is more likely to be acceptable to Russia, thus avoiding a confrontation with Russia during a delicate period of our relations, and reducing the prospect that Russia would come to the aid of the Serbs to counterbalance our efforts
- A limited approach would place smaller financial burdens on the United States, and reduce (though not eliminate) the risk of US casualties. Defining the objective as defense of current territory improves the prospect for an early hand-off to the Bosnian government following an initial period of assistance. This should improve the prospects for Congressional support.
- Limited assistance is less likely to provoke a wider Balkan war.
- Limited assistance is less likely to intensify the fighting, therefore reducing the humanitarian consequences.

~~SECRET~~

Diplomatic Strategy

In the wake of the Serb attacks on the eastern enclaves and the Croatian offensive, there is an urgent need to expand the thrust of the current negotiations with Milosevic in two dimensions:

- speed up the linkage between Plan B (relief for Milosevic in return for border closure and recognition) and Plan A (cease-fire and negotiations between Sarajevo and Pale) and
- resolve the Krajina situation

A "Bosnia only" strategy is increasingly difficult to execute given the growing connections between the Bosnian and Croatia government through the Federation and Confederation, and the likelihood that the most likely successful long-term outcome will involve close political links between Bosnia and Croatia. As the negotiation becomes more complex, deeper US involvement in the negotiating track is essential, since only the United States has adequate clout with all the parties.

The elements of the approach are as follows:

1. A sanctions suspension package is agreed "in principle" with Milosevic and a Security Council Resolution is introduced, but implementation through final Security Council action is withheld pending progress on the ground and movement toward a negotiated settlement (elements 2-4, below).
2. Izetbegovic meets with Milosevic to confirm recognition agreement, border closure provisions and reiterate support for Contact Group plan. They agree on principles to govern a political settlement in Bosnia, which could include two autonomous entities within a single state in existing borders, respect for Bosnia's sovereignty, protection of minority rights, etc.
3. Sarajevo offers to negotiate with Pale based on the principles announced with Milosevic and the Contact Group plan, with some modification of the "accept the Contact Group plan as a starting point" formula. The parties would also agree to a cessation of hostilities and disengagement of forces in conjunction with the beginning of the bilateral negotiations.
4. Pale and Sarajevo begin negotiations and ceasefire begins.

~~SECRET~~

Decl: OADR

CLINTON LIBRARY PHOTOCOPY

5. The Security Council adopts the sanctions suspension package

6. Izetbegovic, Milosevic and Tudjman meet to announce agreement on recognition and "principles" governing political settlement in Croatia, including political and human rights, some political provisions governing Krajina, perhaps a deferral of Sector East as "final status" issue to be negotiated later. Croatia would be "recognized" subject to the limitations with respect to Sector East. Meeting could be hosted by EU or Contact Group.

6. Ceasefire and draw back implemented and Bilateral negotiations begin.

Possible Variant

This approach may pose an important difficulty for Bosnia, since the government has now said that any "recognition for sanctions suspension" deal with Milosevic must also include Croatia. The approach is also likely to meet objections from Milosevic because it does not allow implementation of the sanctions suspension package until the Pale-Sarajevo negotiations begin. These two problems could be solved by accelerating the "three Presidents" meeting and implementing sanctions suspension before the bilateral Sarajevo-Pale negotiations begin. The sequence would be:

1. Sanctions suspension package agreed (as above).
2. Izetbegovic, Tudjman and Milosevic meet, agree on mutual recognition (with provision as above to defer Sector East), and establish principles for settlement of both bilateral conflicts (Sarajevo-Pale; Croatia-Croatian Serbs). They invite the relevant parties (Sarajevo/Pale and Croatia/RSK) to negotiate on the basis of (acceptance of) these principles.
3. Security Council implements sanctions relief package

Other provisions as above:

The principal difficulty with this variant is that Milosevic has adamantly resisted recognizing Croatia, and the current fighting could make this even more difficult in the short run. Since we have always been prepared to give Milosevic additional sanctions relief in conjunction with progress on Croatia, it is possible that his resistance could be overcome by sweetening the initial sanctions suspension package with sanctions lift. Moving to this approach would be a significant departure from the proposal we gave Bildt, so probably could not be deployed unless the first approach failed to get off the ground.

How would this initiative be launched?

1. (already accomplished) Carl Bildt meets with Milosevic, outlining US concerns over the current package of sanctions relief, and the need to improve the "situation on the ground" in Bosnia before any sanctions suspension can be implemented. Bildt suggests that a senior US official meet with Milosevic to discuss US concerns. Milosevic agrees.
2. (in approximately 7-10 days, depending on events in Croatia) A senior level official (e.g. Assistant Secretary Holbrooke) goes to first to Sarajevo to lay out overall strategy and gain the Bosnians' cooperation. This is followed by a visit to Belgrade to discuss our approach.
3. Belgrade and Sarajevo foreign ministers meet privately to work out details (they are already talking about meeting).
4. Milosevic and Izetbegovic meet (with or without "host").
5. Cease-fire and disengagement implemented as bilateral talks between Sarajevo and Pale begin, either face-to-face or through mediator. (US? Contact Group?)
6. Three presidents meet under aegis of EU or Contact Group.
7. Bilateral talks between Croatian parties begin.

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

This is not a presidential record. This is used as an administrative marker by the William J. Clinton Presidential Library Staff.

Documents from this Mandatory Declassification Review were released in full.
